



Economics

China Macro

Date

9 June 2026

Trade momentum accelerated further

China's trade momentum accelerated further in May, supported by continued "AHEAD" factors and rising trade flows in energy and petrochemical products.

Exports rose further to 19.4% YoY from 14% in the first four months. In seasonally adjusted terms, exports reached a new historical high. "[AHEAD](#)" factors remained the dominant drivers, contributing 16ppts to headline growth. Within this, AI-related exports saw a significant step-up, with growth doubling to 81% YoY in May (vs. 42% in Jan-Apr), lifting their contribution to 10ppts from 5ppts. In addition, energy and petrochemical exports strengthened notably, with refined oil exports rebounding from -1% to +27% YoY, and plastics accelerating from 7% to 12% YoY. This underscores China's pricing advantage in energy-intensive sectors.

By destination, emerging markets remained strong, while shipments to advanced economies re-accelerated sharply. Total exports to ASEAN, Africa, and Latin America held steady at around 18% YoY, contributing 6ppts to overall growth. Meanwhile, exports to major developed markets, including the US, Japan, South Korea, and Taiwan, surged, with combined growth jumping from 2% to 30% YoY, largely driven by strong AI-related demand. The rebound in exports to the US also likely reflected tariff disruption, as May last year was a low base, while tariff easing and the recent bilateral engagement have supported a gradual normalization in trade flows.

Import growth also accelerated to 27.4% YoY from 23%. In line with export trends, machinery products, particularly AI-related goods, continued to gain momentum, while metals like copper imports remained on a rising trend. Notably, energy imports strengthened significantly. Earlier increases in energy exports from major suppliers to China in March–April had not yet been reflected in China's import data; the May release now captures this lag, with sharp accelerations in imports of crude oil, coal, and natural gas.

We reiterate our full-year forecasts of 12% export growth and 15% import growth. Risks are tilted to the upside, if momentum in energy and petrochemical trade further strengthen. Against the backdrop of strong trade activity, we remain [constructive on the RMB](#), expecting appreciation to 6.55 by end-2026 and further to 6.30 by 2027.

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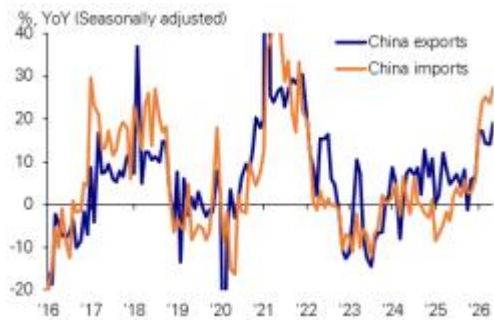
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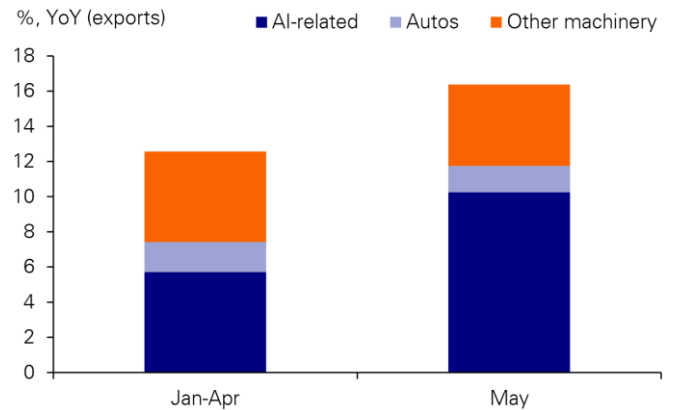


Figure 1: China's trade momentum accelerated further



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, Haver Analytics

Figure 2: "AHEAD" factors remained the dominant drivers



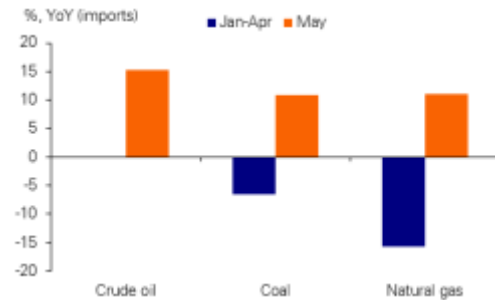
Source: Deutsche Bank Research, CEIC. Note: AI-related products include integrated circuits, mobile phones, computers, and other data processing equipment.

Figure 3: Exports to major developed markets surged



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, CEIC

Figure 4: Energy imports strengthened significantly



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, CEIC



Appendix 1

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